Chapter 2

Taking Charge of Your Health

1. Building Health Skills
2. Making Responsible Decisions and Setting Goals
3. Being a Health-Literate Consumer
4. Managing Consumer Problems

Lesson 1 — Building Health Skills

Health skills — also called life skills — are the tools and strategies you use to protect, maintain, and improve your health. Once you build them, they stick with you for life.

The Core Health Skills

- **Communication** — Sharing ideas and feelings clearly while genuinely listening to others. Use 'I' statements, stay calm, be an active listener.
- **Refusal Skills** — Say no firmly, respectfully, and confidently when pressured into something that goes against your values or health.
- **Conflict Resolution** — Ending disagreements through cooperation and problem-solving. Often involves compromise — both sides give a little to gain a result everyone can live with.
- **Accessing Information** — Finding reliable health info. Use .gov and .edu sites, health professionals, and recently published work from respected experts.
- **Analyzing Influences** — Recognizing what shapes your choices — values, family, culture, friends, media. Self-awareness leads to better decisions.
- **Practicing Healthful Behaviors** — Making good habits part of your daily routine — eating well, sleeping enough, staying active, avoiding harmful substances.
- **Stress Management** — Stress is normal, but too much unmanaged stress makes you sick. Exercise, relaxation, and time management all help.
- **Advocacy** — Taking action to encourage others to make healthy choices or support health-related causes.
- **Decision Making** — Using a thoughtful step-by-step process to make responsible choices.
- **Goal Setting** — Setting targets for yourself and building a plan to reach them.

Lesson 2 — Making Responsible Decisions & Setting Goals

The 6-Step Decision-Making Process

Good decisions start with your **values** — the beliefs and attitudes that guide the way you live. When a decision feels hard, talking it through with family is often a great move.

1	**State the Situation** What exactly do I need to decide?
2	**List the Options** What are all the possible choices?
3	**Weigh the Outcomes** Use the HELP strategy — Healthful, Ethical, Legal, Parent Approval
4	**Consider Values** Does this choice align with what matters to me?
5	**Make a Decision and Act** Commit to it.
6	**Evaluate the Decision** How did it go? What would I do differently?

Setting Goals: The S.M.A.R.T. Framework

Goals are things you aim for that take planning and effort. The reason most goals fail is that they're too vague. S.M.A.R.T. goals fix that:

S — Specific	Clearly define what you want. Example: 'Drink 8 glasses of water every day' not 'be healthier'
M — Measurable	Make sure you can track progress. Example: 'Run 3x a week' not 'exercise more'
A — Achievable	Challenge yourself but stay realistic. Training for a 5K is achievable; a marathon next week is not.
R — Relevant	Connect the goal to something that matters. If you want to make the basketball team, stamina is relevant.
T — Time-bound	Give yourself a deadline. 'Cut out soda for 30 days' not 'someday I'll eat better'

> Weak goal: 'I want to sleep more.' → S.M.A.R.T. goal: 'I will be in bed by 10:30 PM on school nights for the next two weeks.'

Short-term goals are stepping stones to long-term goals. Build an **action plan** — write down your goal, list the steps, identify who can support you, set a timeline, create checkpoints, and celebrate when you succeed.

Lesson 3 — Being a Health-Literate Consumer

Every day you make buying decisions — and when it comes to health products and services, being a smart **health consumer** really matters. The biggest influence on your buying decisions? **Advertising** — media messages designed to get you to buy something.

Common Advertising Techniques to Watch For

Bandwagon	"Everyone's doing it!"
Testimonial	"It worked for me!"
Rich & Famous	Making a product look luxurious
Good Times	Showing happy people using the product
Great Outdoors	Using nature imagery to seem healthy
Free Gifts	Making deals feel too good to pass up

How to Shop Smart

- **Read product labels** — Ingredients listed by weight (most to least). Active ingredients are what make a product work.
- **Comparison shopping** — Compare cost, quality, features, and safety ratings before buying. Generics often work just as well as brand names.
- **Check the warranty** — A written promise to repair or replace a product if it doesn't work properly.
- **Safety certifications** — Underwriters Laboratories (UL) for appliances; ANSI for helmets and protective gear.
- **Use trusted sources** — For health info online, use .gov or .edu sites, or organizations like the CDC or American Medical Association.

Lesson 4 — Managing Consumer Problems

When a Product Doesn't Work

1. Read the warranty and return policy before you buy
2. Follow the instructions carefully
3. If still not working, contact the manufacturer
4. If unresolved, reach out to the Better Business Bureau, consumer advocates, or the FDA

Watch Out for Health Fraud

Health fraud (also called quackery) is the sale of worthless products or services claiming to cure or prevent health problems. Weight loss and beauty products are especially common targets.

Red flags:

- "Secret formula"
- "Miracle cure"
- "Overnight results"
- "All natural"
- "Hurry — offer expires soon!"

> Before buying anything that sounds too good to be true, check with a doctor, the Better Business Bureau, or a professional health organization like the American Heart Association.

Chapter Vocabulary

Lesson 1

Health skills	Specific tools and strategies to maintain, protect, and improve all aspects of your health; also called life skills
Interpersonal communication	The exchange of thoughts, feelings, and beliefs between two or more people
Refusal skills	Communication strategies that help you say no to unsafe or unhealthful behaviors
Conflict resolution	The process of ending a conflict through cooperation and problem solving
Stress	The reaction of the body and mind to everyday challenges and demands
Stress management skills	Skills that help you reduce and manage stress in your life
Advocacy	Taking action to influence others to address a health-related concern or support a health-related belief

Lesson 2

Values	The ideas, beliefs, and attitudes about what is important that help guide the way you live
Decision-making skills	Steps that enable you to make a healthful decision
Goals	Things you aim for that take planning and work
Short-term goal	A goal you can reach in a short period of time
Long-term goal	A goal you plan to reach over an extended period of time
Action plan	A multistep strategy to identify and achieve your goals
S.M.A.R.T. goals	A goal-setting framework where goals are Specific, Measurable, Achievable, Relevant, and Time-bound

Lesson 3

Health consumer	Someone who purchases or uses health products or services
Advertising	A written or spoken media message designed to interest consumers in purchasing a product or service
Comparison shopping	Judging the benefits of different products by comparing factors such as quality, features, and cost
Warranty	A company's or store's written agreement to repair a product or refund your money if it doesn't function properly

Lesson 4

Consumer advocates	People or groups whose purpose is to take on consumer issues and inform the public about potential problems
Malpractice	Failure by a health professional to meet accepted standards of care
Health fraud	The sale of worthless products or services that claim to prevent disease or cure health problems; also called quackery